



Pakistan is born

In 1947, Lord Louis Mountbatten flew into Delhi as Britain's final Viceroy of India. Faced with irreconcilable differences over the demand for a separate state for India's Muslims, he persuaded all parties to agree to partitioning the country into Hindu India and Muslim Pakistan.

From its birth, Pakistan faced many challenges. It had limited resources and a huge refugee problem. There were different traditions, cultures, and languages, and Jinnah, its first governor general, died the following year. In 1948, India and Pakistan fought over Kashmir, the only Muslim-majority area to remain within India.

Colonies gain freedom

After World War II, the European colonial powers—mainly Britain, France, the Netherlands, and Portugal—recognized that change was inevitable. Some colonies won independence by peaceful means, such as in Burma (Myanmar) and Ceylon (Sri Lanka) in 1948, but often European powers tried to hold on to their colonies.

During World War II, Japan, itself a significant imperial power, drove the European powers out of Asia. After

India's independence was finally declared by Jawaharlal Nehru and Lord Louis Mountbatten at Delhi's Constituent Assembly, just seconds into August 15, 1947.

the Japanese surrender in 1945, nationalist movements in the former Asian colonies campaigned for independence rather than a return to European colonial rule. Dr. Ahmed Sukarno, leader of Indonesia's nationalist movement, declared the Independent Republic of Indonesia in 1945. The Dutch sent troops to restore their authority, and in two military campaigns that followed, an estimated 150,000 Indonesians and 5,000 Dutch soldiers died. International pressure eventually forced the Dutch to concede independence in 1949.

The Japanese occupation of Malaya during the war had unified the Malayan people and greatly increased nationalistic feelings. Britain clamped down on protests, which led the militant wing of the Malaysian Communist Party to declare war on the British Empire in 1948. Britain responded by declaring a state of emergency and pursuing a bitter campaign against Chinese "communist terrorists." Independence was not granted to Malaya until 1957.